

In Phase 6, reading for the great majority of children should become automatic. However, proficiency with spelling usually lags behind proficiency with reading. This is because spelling requires recalling and composing the word from memory without seeing it. Reading and spelling become less easily reversible as children start working with words containing sounds (particularly vowel sounds) which can be spelled in more than one way. Phase 6 is a good time to focus more sharply on word-specific spellings and broad guidelines for making choices between spelling alternatives.

By the beginning of Phase 6, children should know most of the common grapheme-phoneme correspondences (GPCs). They should be able to read hundreds of words, doing this in three ways:

- Reading the words automatically if they are very familiar.
- Decoding them quickly and silently because their sounding and blending routine is now well established.
- Decoding them aloud.

Children's spelling should be phonemically accurate, although it may still be a little unconventional at times. Spelling falls behind reading, as it is harder. Children should also be familiar with the various parts of speech before learning suffixes, as they need to understand the effect of adding a suffix to a word and how the word changes meaning (Parts of speech are defined in the Glossary on page 304).

During this phase, children become fluent readers and increasingly accurate spellers. They should also continue to learn spelling conventions for adding affixes to words. Most children will have taken words with suffixes in their stride in reading, but for spelling purposes they now need more systematic teaching both of the suffixes themselves and of how the spelling of root words may change when suffixes are added.

Letter Progression

Phase 6 – Affixes

un-	dis-	mis-	-s/es	-ies	-ing	-ed	-er
-est	-y	-ly	-ness	-ment	-ful	-less	-en
-le, -el, -al, -il		homophones		contractions		dictionary work and proof reading	